

ran with minimal frame drops, and even demanding AAA titles like Resident Evil Village and Assassin's Creed Mirage performed well, with only occasional stutters. While the iPhone 16 Pro Max doesn't quite match the buttery smooth gaming experience of the iQOO 12, it does support AAA games, which the iQOO 12 lacks. In synthetic benchmarks, the iPhone 16 Pro Max topped the charts in Geekbench scores, but fell behind in GPU-intensive tests like AnTuTu. Rivals such as the Xiaomi 14, Samsung Galaxy S24 Ultra, Vivo X100 Pro, iQOO 12, and OnePlus 12 outperformed it in these tests. However, these benchmark scores are just numbers. For the average user, the differences are hardly noticeable in day-to-day use. Software and Apple Intelligence: iOS 18 and Apple Intelligence Awaiting Full Rollout

During Apple's iPhone 16 Pro Max launch event, they spent a lot of time highlighting the new Apple Intelligence features. But here's the catch—the phone doesn't actually come with these features out of the box. It ships with iOS 18, but Apple Intelligence will only arrive with the iOS 18.1 update, and even then, it's available only in U.S. English.

For users in India, this means you'll have to change your region and Siri language to U.S. English if you want early access. However, this workaround may disrupt features like App Store payments, so it's not an ideal solution. Support for Indian English is expected sometime next year, though there's no exact timeline yet.

I went through the process of switching regions and languages to test these features using the iOS 18.1 beta. While some features are already available, many won't roll out until later in the year. "Clean Up," for instance, feels a bit behind compared to similar features on Android phones, making occasional mistakes in categorizing files. However, the new Siri has shown significant improvements, and features like notification summary and email/article summary are proving quite handy. Unfortunately, Visual Intelligence is still missing from the beta.

In terms of overall software, iOS 18 remains smooth and responsive, with fluid animations and a highly intuitive

interface. You now have the freedom to move app icons anywhere on the home screen—a feature Android users have enjoyed for years.

CAMERAS

The iPhone 16 Pro Max introduces some exciting upgrades to its already excellent camera system. In ideal lighting conditions, the camera delivers stunning results, offering remarkable detail and outstanding colour accuracy, maintaining Apple's reputation for top-notch image quality. However, in challenging lighting, the phone tends to crush shadows, resulting in a loss of detail in darker areas. While this can be a downside for some users, the overall image quality remains strong. Portrait mode is especially impressive, with 5x zoom shots showcasing crisp detail and striking depth of field. In low light, the iPhone 16 Pro Max excels at reducing noise and managing highlights, though this sometimes gives images an artificial appearance. Apple has also expanded the camera experience with a variety of Photographic Styles this year. These come in two categories: Mood and Undertones. While experimenting with these styles can be fun, they may not become a daily tool for most users.

When it comes to video, the iPhone 16 Pro Max continues to dominate, solidifying its place as the best smartphone for video recording. The ability to capture 4K at 120 FPS makes for impressive slow-motion footage with excellent clarity. The new Audio Mix feature, though intriguing, didn't fully meet expectations, but it adds another layer of flexibility to video creation.

BATTERY LIFE

The iPhone 16 Pro Max's extra capacity has led to an impressive Screen-On Time of 7-8 hours. While video streaming and gaming performance remain similar to what was seen on the iPhone 15 Pro Max, the new model shines in areas like call and web browsing, contributing to the overall improved battery life.

The iPhone 16 Pro Max supports fast wired charging, though Apple doesn't disclose exact power ratings. The company

claims that the device can charge up to 50% in 30 minutes when using a 20W charger. The phone charged from 0-100% in 102 minutes or 1 hour and 42 minutes, according to our tests. As indicated by Apple, it reached 48% in 30 minutes, but charging the phone post that, especially the last 20%, is laboriously slow.

VERDICT

The iPhone 16 Pro Max is a true powerhouse, offering premium build quality, stellar performance, and top-tier cameras. Its battery life has also seen significant improvements, making it a dependable option for power users. However, the absence of Apple's AI features, especially in markets like India, gives the phone a somewhat unfinished feel. It feels like a work in progress in some areas. And the new camera control button, far from being revolutionary, actually feels more like a gimmick. You have to press it hard enough that it often causes unnecessary shake and blur in your images, detracting from its intended convenience.

Despite these drawbacks, the iPhone 16 Pro Max remains the best iPhone ever made. The level of polish in both hardware and software is undeniable, even though some elements feel incomplete. If you're upgrading from an iPhone 13 Pro Max or older, the improvements will genuinely impress you. However, if you already own an iPhone 14 Pro Max or 15 Pro Max, the upgrades are too incremental to justify the switch. Moreover, if AI capabilities are a priority for you, alternatives from Pixel and Samsung offer a more complete and advanced experience in this regard.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Apple A18 Pro | GPU: Apple GPU (6-core) | OS: iOS 18 | RAM: 8 GB | Internal Storage: Up to 1 TB | Display: 6.9" LTPO OLED, HDR10+, Dolby Vision, 1320 x 2868 pixels | Display refresh rate: 120 Hz | Battery capacity: 4685 mAh | Charging: Wired PD 2.0, 25 W Wireless (MagSafe) | Cameras: 48 MP + 48 MP + 12 MP | Selfie camera: 12 MP | Video: Up to 4K at 120 FPS | Display protection: Ceramic Shield | IP rating: IP68 | Weight: 227 g

CONTACT

Company: Apple | Phone: 008001009009 | Email: NA | Website: <https://www.apple.com/in/>